THE PUBLIC PAPERS AND ADDRESSES OF FRANKLIN D. ROOSEVELT

COMPILED WITH SPECIAL MATERIAL AND EXPLANATORY NOTES BY

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1944-45 Volume

VICTORY AND THE THRESHOLD OF PEACE

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Introduction

IN THIS final volume, covering the last fifteen months of President Roosevelt's life, there appear public papers and addresses which reflect almost every facet of the leadership which he had exercised from the day he entered the White House. The earliest volumes of this series — those covering the first and second terms — embodied the words of a New Deal President who had an abiding faith in the vitality of the United States and in its expanding democracy, and who fought — successfully — for the economic freedom and security of the common man. With the beginning of the third term, the emphasis shifted. The major task began to be to lead the Nation in preparing for defense, and in aiding the Allies who were resisting the Axis.

After December 7, 1941, of course, the President was necessarily committed principally to war leadership. But, as the tide of war changed in 1943, postwar problems — both international and domestic — began to take their place alongside military and production problems. In the public papers and addresses of the President in this volume there is a synthesis of his leadership during all his years of office.

First, as in the two preceding volumes, there are disclosed the activities of the President as a military leader. That leadership is reflected in the rising tide of victories noted in his public words: the fall of Rome, the invasion of Normandy, the liberation of the Low Countries, the fall of Paris, the landing in the Philippines and their liberation. There are also the great military conferences of the last year of the war: the second Quebec Conference and the conference at Yalta.

As in the two preceding volumes, there are also the words of the military leader who was concerned with problems of the home front, because he knew how much victory in battle depended on the solution of these problems at home. However, there is reflected some shift in the urgency of those problems. By 1944, the battle of production had been won, and the major danger was overconfidence which would have made heavy inroads on

production. Similarly, the main outlines of the stabilization program were in effect and, during 1944, the struggle was to keep the program from destruction at the hands of a few groups still insisting on special privileges. While the President did continue to speak of the problems of production and stabilization during this period, the problem of providing sufficient manpower became the most difficult one to solve.

The huge drain upon manpower caused by military service created an acute shortage. It was accentuated by a tendency on the part of many workers to regard the war as nearly over and to drift away from work in war plants. The more difficult kinds of war work and some of the essential civilian industries were unable to compete for labor. And so, in this volume, came the President's urgent — but unheeded — call for national service legislation. That legislation was certainly among the most drastic for which the President asked. Happily, it turned out not to be necessary. But he recommended it when he did not yet know — as nobody knew — that our atomic research would succeed and that the end of the war was not far off. Certainly if the invasion of Japan had been necessary, as the military leaders thought in 1944, the national service legislation which the President requested would have been a vital essential.

Two aspects of President Roosevelt's leadership in 1944, however, were not directly concerned with the war, but rather reverted to the leadership of his first two terms. There was the resurgence of the President as a fighting liberal. There was also his reappearance as a fighting candidate.

I recall well that, during the war, a number of my friends — early New Dealers and very ardent liberals — used to shake their heads rather dolefully about the President. In 1942 and 1943, some of them used to say that Roosevelt had lost his liberal fervor, that he was becoming a tired New Dealer who had shifted to the right. The President knew about this criticism, and, in due time, answered it publicly. At his last press conference in 1943, the President explained that he had called in "Dr. Win-the-War" to substitute for "Dr. New Deal," but only until vic-

tory came. For victory was the first essential, and since 1933 the President had insisted always on putting "first things first." He promised the American people that, after the war, he would continue to fight for a liberal program along greatly expanded lines. As victory became more certain in 1944, he began to make good on his promise. This volume reflects the President as the fighting liberal again — hitting sharply at poll taxes, urging more valley authorities in the pattern of the T.V.A., vetoing an inequitable tax bill which would have provided "relief not for the needy but for the greedy," reassuring the Nation that he was still "a little left of center," and, most important of all, laying a firm groundwork for a postwar New Deal whose charter was to be the President's Economic Bill of Rights.

In this volume, too, the President reappears as perhaps the greatest of all American political campaigners. The 1944 campaign against Thomas E. Dewey, in which the President won election to a fourth term, was an extraordinary one. In its early phases, there was no campaign at all. Dewey had the stage to himself, making a series of precise and calculated orations — gaining votes, while the President remained silent.

But the President was, as he liked to call himself so often, an "old campaigner." He could not remain silent too long. He knew that Dewey was gaining ground and that there could be no excitement in a campaign in which only one candidate was campaigning. He recognized that Dewey's best chance for election depended on an apathetic public and a small vote, especially with twelve million young men and women in the armed forces. And so he broke the campaign wide open in September, 1944, with his famous "Fala" speech before the Teamsters' Union. The speech had just the results which the President intended. It brought fresh enthusiasm to the public and to Democratic Party workers. And it caused Dewey to abandon his cool orations — and to start swinging wildly. Above all, it showed that the President was still a masterful political campaigner. That was emphasized by his memorable, gallant tour of New York City through a pouring rainstorm. The rumors about his bad health, current in all his

campaigns, had been increasing in volume and in bitterness in the campaign of 1944. As he rode in an open car for miles and miles, the rain pouring on him — for millions to see — the rumors, at least temporarily, began to quiet down.

It was a source of wonder at the time — and still is — that after almost twelve years of the most severe punishment public office can deal out, Roosevelt was able to pitch into a national campaign and tire out most of those who campaigned with him. There were several reasons for his campaign enthusiasm.

The first was his personal dislike for his opponent. I served closely with Roosevelt in six of his campaigns for public office, and the only opponent toward whom I knew he had a feeling of strong personal dislike was Governor Dewey. My belief is that that feeling was the result of the campaign tactics of the Governor to which the President occasionally alluded in his own campaign speeches; and that it came also from a conviction, which he occasionally expressed, that Dewey really was not the sincere internationalist he professed to be. In the early 1940's, Dewey had been rather consistently opposed to the wing of the Republican Party led by that great internationalist, Wendell L. Willkie. Many of Dewey's public statements, as well as his political associations, seemed to reflect a lack of enthusiasm for internationalism. So when Dewey came out for certain internationalist principles in 1944, it almost appeared to some that he was taking this course with one eye on the public opinion polls, rather than from any deep internationalist convictions.

Roosevelt's enthusiasm was also fired by the blunt feeling that it would take a person with experience in dealing with the other United Nations to finish the delicate task of peace building; and that because of his own experience in the last four years he could finish the job better than his opponent. The vigor and intensity of his campaign were a rude surprise to those who sought to defeat him by constant repetition that his administration was that of a "tired old man."

This volume, then, reflects the President's military leadership on the war front and the home front, his domestic liberalism,

and his superb mastery of political campaigning. But, to an even greater degree than 1943, this volume reflects also the President's overwhelming emphasis on precise and detailed planning for the future — for a postwar world in which there would be peace, and for a postwar United States in which there would be the economic stability so essential to world peace. To both postwar objectives the President devoted major attention.

In his report to the Congress and to the American people on the Yalta Conference, March 1, 1945, President Roosevelt accurately said: "This time we are not making the mistake of waiting until the end of the war to set up the machinery of peace. This time, as we fight together to win the war finally, we work together to keep it from happening again."

That statement is the index of the major objective of the President during the year 1944 and the early months of 1945. In 1943, as the course of war changed in our favor, plans had been laid to create a United Nations organization and a postwar world of the kind envisaged in the Atlantic Charter of August, 1941. In 1944 and 1945, the plans progressed.

By March, 1945, the President was able conscientiously and sincerely to say: "Never before have the major Allies been more closely united — not only in their war aims but also in their peace aims. And they are determined to continue to be united with each other — and with all peace-loving Nations — so that the ideal of lasting peace will become a reality."

Although Roosevelt had "never for an instant wavered in (his) belief that an agreement to insure world peace and security (could) be reached," he had gone through more than four years of patient international negotiation on all kinds of matters of common interest. He had learned that it was not always easy. There were times when the Allied leaders — military and civilian — did not see eye to eye on a great many issues. That is one of the reasons why so many international conferences and overseas trips had to take place. Differences had to be ironed out. Very often relations were quite strained. Such subjects as when and where and how the second front was to be established, or how the

limited war supplies of 1941 and 1942 were to be allocated, or how Germany was to be controlled and handled immediately after the war — all of these grave questions and many more were potential areas of dispute among the Allies. Fortunately, the willingness to negotiate and reason and explain, and the practice of meeting together face to face minimized differences.

Many of these differences have now been revealed; to have revealed them at the time they occurred would have provided the enemy with too much military information and too much ammunition for propaganda. Reaching agreement was not always simple. The American people, who read the communiqués or joint statements issued after these international conferences or visits, had little knowledge of the patient effort and striving for accord which were required in order to come to agreement. But the President and the other participants knew. So when in March, 1945, after all the years of planning and negotiation, he announced the high tide of Allied unity at Yalta, he was expressing a considered and grateful appraisal of the result of the years of work in which he labored.

In gauging the importance of the President's statement that, even while the fighting was going on, the Allies were going to continue to prepare for lasting peace, we must bear in mind a fact which we now know but which Roosevelt and his co-workers did not know. When the San Francisco Conference was set for April 25, 1945, no responsible military or civilian leader dreamed that the war would be over in Japan in less than four months after that date. The best military judgment available indicated that at least a full year, and probably two or more years, would be required before Japan could be made to surrender. No one knew definitely until July, 1945, that we had assembled a successful atomic bomb — three months after Roosevelt's death. It was agreed at Yalta that Russia would come into the war soon against Japan, and that the three Allies would be fighting together in the Pacific as they had in Europe. This is what our own military leaders hoped to accomplish above all else at Yalta.

No one can say what the course of international affairs would have been if, for two years or even one year after San Francisco, the three Big Powers would have had to continue the war against the Japanese together. Would they have fallen apart so soon over European problems? Or would they have held together and become more firmly cemented? No one, of course, can furnish the answer.

It is clear that the President, who from the first saw the advantage of planning together while we were fighting together, contemplated a year or more of Allied fighting after San Francisco — during which time the Big Powers would have had experience in working together as comrades in arms.

Roosevelt ran for the fourth term only because he felt confident that the job of peace building which he had started in his third term could be finished in his fourth. Could he have finished it if he had lived? This is an oft-repeated question. The answer to it is bound to be purely speculative, and can never be formulated with any degree of certainty.

In the note to Item 134, the joint statement of the "Big Three" on the Yalta Conference, February 11, 1945, I have tried to analyze the results of that meeting, and to show where agreements were reached, where they were not, what compromises were made, what concessions were made on each side, and what questions were left open. When the joint statement was issued, there was almost universal praise from writers and commentators on foreign affairs on the results achieved: the agreement as to free elections and self-determination in the liberated areas, the agreement on the organization of the United Nations and the San Francisco Conference, on the control of Germany and on the new government to be set up in Poland. Had the Soviet Union carried out these agreements and adhered to the principles enunciated at Yalta the world would be far along on the road to peace. The peace of the world is now in danger — not because of Yalta, but because the Soviet Union has flouted the specific agreements which were reached at Yalta.

The President was convinced there was one condition pre-

cedent to international security: a strong America — strong economically, physically, and spiritually. If the United States was to be the leading spirit, its spirit had to be strong. Planning to achieve this domestic objective of a strong America absorbed much of the last year of the President's life.

In 1943, he had already begun to plan for the foundations of a postwar America. His first concern was for the veterans themselves; but in that concern there was the realization of the need of providing a sound economy for all into which veterans might return and fit their lives. It was not only the immediate future about which he thought and for which he planned. His sights were lifted to certain long-range objectives, which he felt had become essentials in a modern democracy but which had been too long neglected in the United States. These objectives became formalized in his State of the Union message at the very beginning of 1944, in the "Economic Bill of Rights."

The Economic Bill of Rights was to supplement our old political Bill of Rights, under the protection of which "this Republic had its beginning, and grew to its present strength." The supplement was necessary because, in an expanding industrial economy, true individual freedom did not depend alone on political rights; it required also "economic security and independence."

Such rights he listed: the right to a job at a living wage; the right to a decent home; to medical care and the opportunity to achieve and enjoy good health; freedom from the economic fears of old age, sickness, accident, and unemployment; freedom from monopolies and unfair competition; the right to an education. This kind of a program spelled security, and the President said: "Unless there is security here at home there cannot be lasting peace in the world."

This was not the sort of program which he expected to be passed at once as soon as the war ended. He was realistic enough to know that it would require fighting for, that it was worth fighting for, and that there would be bitter opposition to it. Later events in the 80th Congress and even in the 81st have shown how bitter the opposition was going to be. But the battle lines on

which would be determined the kind of postwar America we are to have were laid down six months before the landings in France — and they are still the battle lines between liberals and conservatives.

In his Chicago campaign speech on October 28, 1944, he expressed confidence that the battle would end in victory: "I know that they (the American people) agree with these objectives — that they demand them — that they are determined to get them — and that they are *going* to get them."

He had seen the American people do so much under proper leadership that his faith in what they could do was unbounded. He had seen them rise from the depths of the depression of 1929-1932; he had seen them produce weapons for defense and for war in "fantastic" quantities; he had seen them raise and train an armed force that was defeating the most cruelly efficient military machine ever assembled by oppressor Nations. He did not live to see them carry forward the tasks called for by the planning of 1943 and 1944. But he had complete faith that they could — if only they would keep their own faith. In the last prepared address included in this volume — a speech he did not live to make — he exhorted the American people to hold to that faith:

"Today as we move against the terrible scourge of war — as we go forward toward the greatest contribution that any generation of human beings can make in this world — the contribution of lasting peace, I ask you to keep up your faith. I measure the sound, solid achievement that can be made at this time by the straight edge of your own confidence and your resolve. . . . The only limit to our realization of tomorrow will be our doubts of today. Let us move forward with strong and active faith."

His faith in what the American people could do if only they kept the faith has been justified even after Roosevelt's death. They have steadfastly moved forward, wherever they could, in the quest for peace and international accord; they have resisted the advances and threats and challenge of the new dictators and aggressors in the Soviet Union and its satellites; they have sought

to carry forward the principles of the Atlantic Charter; they are still behind the New Deal and the Economic Bill of Rights.

He no longer can lead them, but the strong and active faith which he did so much to instill in this Nation is carrying it forward to the goals which he set.



New York, N. Y.
October 6, 1949

120 ¶ The Nine Hundred and Eighty-fourth Press Conference (Excerpts).

December 19, 1944

(The President is "a little left of center" — What the Atlantic Charter is.)

THE PRESIDENT: I haven't got any news.

Q. Mr. President, Mr. Bevin said in London last week that you initialed the Quebec British plan for British stabilization of Greece. Could you tell us anything about that?

THE PRESIDENT: Wasn't that denied?

Q. Don't think so, sir.

THE PRESIDENT: State Department? I think so.

Q. No, sir.

THE PRESIDENT: Well, I think they said something in a more polite form than that.

Q. Is it to be denied, Mr. President?

THE PRESIDENT: I wouldn't bring it up again. I think it's contentious. I found a new word when I was away: contentious. *(Laughter)* I wouldn't bring it up. There is nothing in that. . . .

MAY CRAIG: Mr. President, this is a contentious question, but I would like a serious answer. *(Laughter)*

THE PRESIDENT: You would find it awful hard to get, May.

MAY CRAIG: There's a good deal of question as to whether you are going right or left politically, and I would like your opinion on which way you are going?

THE PRESIDENT: I am going down the whole line a little left of center. I think that was answered, that question, eleven and a half years ago, and still holds.

Q. But you told us a little while ago that you were going to have Dr. Win-The-War and not Dr. New Deal.

THE PRESIDENT: *(interjecting)* That's right.

Q. (continuing) The question is whether you are going back to be Dr. New Deal after the war —

THE PRESIDENT: *(interposing)* No, no. No. Keep right along a little to the left of center, which includes winning the war. That's not much of an answer, is it?

MAY CRAIG: No. *(Laughter)*

THE PRESIDENT: However, you have broken the ice, May.

Q. Mr. President, if you are going down a little left of center, how does that match with the six appointments you sent up to the Hill on the State Department?

THE PRESIDENT: Very well.

Q. Would you call them a little left of center?

THE PRESIDENT: I call myself a little left of center. I have got a lot of people in the Administration — oh, I know some of them are extreme right and extreme left, and everything else — a lot of people in the Administration, and I cannot vouch for them all. They work out pretty well, on the whole. Just think, this crowd here in this room — my gracious, you will find every opinion between left and extreme right.

Q. Mr. President, would you welcome, and do you see the prospect of an early conference with Mr. Churchill and Mr. Stalin?

THE PRESIDENT: I saw that. Yes. A highly speculative story.

Q. I asked you if you saw the prospect of an early conference?

THE PRESIDENT: I said it's highly — highly — what? — what was the word I used about it? — speculative.

Q. I would like to eliminate the speculation and go to the highest source. *(Laughter)*

THE PRESIDENT: I know you would. So would I. You are not the only one. *(More laughter)*

Q. Mr. President, in being a little left of center, you have noticed in your life that many a progressive or liberal stays where he is and becomes hopelessly conservative as time goes on.

THE PRESIDENT: And you are exactly the same age as I am.

Q. Yes.

THE PRESIDENT: Now, do you feel that you are getting more conservative?

MR. GODWIN: I think I am.

THE PRESIDENT: Well, that's bad. You must be older than I am. *(Laughter)* Old age hasn't crept up on me yet. You ought to be careful. You ought to watch that; it's a serious thing when it happens. . . .

Q. Mr. President, did Mr. Churchill ever sign the Atlantic Charter?

THE PRESIDENT: Nobody ever signed the Atlantic Charter. Now that's an amazing statement.

Q. Where is it, Mr. President?

THE PRESIDENT: Well, you're thinking in awfully — oh, what will I say? — banal phrases and thought.

There isn't any copy of the Atlantic Charter, so far as I know. I haven't got one. The British haven't got one. The nearest thing you will get is the radio operator on the *Augusta* and on the *Prince of Wales*. That's the nearest thing you will come to it. It's one of the things that was agreed to on board ship, and there was no formal document.

And the aides were directed to have the scribbled thing, which had a great many corrections, some I suppose in Mr. Churchill's handwriting, and some in mine, and some in Sir Alec Cadogan's handwriting, some in scraps of paper, some in Sumner Welles's handwriting — and the aides were directed to have it sent off to the British Government, and to the United States Government, and released to the press. That is the Atlantic Charter.

Q. Well, Mr. President, is it not true that all of the United Nations have signed the —

THE PRESIDENT: *(interposing)* Oh, yes.

Q. *(continuing)* — obligations of the Atlantic Charter through the Declaration of Washington?

THE PRESIDENT: Yes, that was done on the first of January, 1942, and that's all signed.

There was one amusing thing that happened to it. The original was, I think, typewritten in the State Department. And finally, on the first of January, 1942, the Ambassadors came in a great part of that day. We had two or three sessions.

And we all signed up. And then a little later on Brazil and a couple of other countries signed, over in the Dining Room in the White House, which was all decorated with flags.

That's where I got caught. Nobody caught on. The press was there, though.

And the Brazilian Ambassador was sitting on my right, and the copy wasn't there! I delivered a speech, and then asked the signatory powers to sign. But there was nothing to sign. It was in the Department safe, and the keeper of the Department safe who knew the combination was out in Bethesda, which didn't help at all.

And I said all right, we haven't got the document for you to sign; and I wrote out longhand very simple words: we hereby approve and join in the Declaration by the United Nations set up on the first of January last.

But before writing it, I looked for a pen, and there wasn't any pen! — *(laughter)* — because the pen wouldn't work — didn't have any ink in it. It finally ended by my borrowing the pen — I used really strong language — luckily I wasn't on the air — *(more laughter)* — as to the lack of pens, and I borrowed the fountain pen of the Mexican Ambassador.

Q. Mr. President, that Statement that was issued to the press said it was a Statement signed by yourself and by the British Prime Minister. Is that literally not true, sir, that it was merely presented through you — that it was not a document —

THE PRESIDENT: *(interposing)* What Statement to the press?

Q. When the Atlantic Charter Statement was issued?

THE PRESIDENT: Yes.

Q. Issued through the White House.

THE PRESIDENT: It isn't a formal document. He [Churchill] has got a lot of his handwriting — some of mine — in it, and I don't know where it is now.

Q. I understand that, sir, but the caption on that Statement that we received said it was a Statement signed by yourself and the British Prime Minister. I was just trying to clarify

whether that document actually had signatures on the bottom of it, or whether it did not?

THE PRESIDENT: Oh, I think it's probable, in time, they will find some documents and signatures.

Q. The spirit still is there, sir?

THE PRESIDENT: Well, we all agreed on it, that's all I know. I have got some memoranda that were signed by the British Prime Minister, but it wasn't the complete document. It isn't considered signed by us both.

Q. My recollection is that the thing that came up to the Capitol said at the bottom, "Signed Roosevelt and Churchill.". . .

THE PRESIDENT: It was signed in substance. There is no formal document — complete document — signed by us both. There are memoranda to the people there and to the radio people.

Q. *(interjecting)* Whether or not it was signed, you promulgated and stood for it, and you stand for it now?

THE PRESIDENT: *(continuing)* And sent for the radio man and said put this on the air. That's all.

Q. Have you, since that time, Mr. President, wished that you had a formal document which was signed, sealed, and attested?

THE PRESIDENT: No, except from the point of view of sightseers in Washington. I think that they will like to see it, perhaps not so much as the Declaration of Independence or the Constitution of the United States. Well, if you wanted to exhibit it, there isn't any good reason we can't.

NOTE: For the official statement on the Atlantic Charter, and subsequent comments by the President on the Atlantic Charter, see Items 74, 76, 77, and 78, 1941 volume; Item 82, 1942 volume; Item 90, 1943 volume; and Item 121, this volume.

121 ¶ The Nine Hundred and Eighty-fifth Press Conference (Excerpts). December 22, 1944

(The Atlantic Charter as a statement of objectives — Columnists.)

Q. Mr. President, may I ask a question about the Atlantic Charter which was discussed at our last press conference? It seems that recently a number of people have felt that we are losing the purposes, or that they are slipping away from us —

THE PRESIDENT: *(interposing)* Again, it depends on which paper you read.

Q. Well, I would like to hear from the President and not merely from others. I would like to know what the President thinks about it?

THE PRESIDENT: Well, I ought to prepare something a little formal and think it over, but I will try it.

There are certain — you might call them documents, because is a telegram a document? — I don't know — "pronouncements," call it that, that in all history have been made. Some of them are of a good deal of importance, some of them do have an effect on the thinking of a public towards objectives, and for a better world.

And the Atlantic Charter stands as an objective. A great many of the previous pronouncements that go back many centuries have not been attained yet, and yet the objective is still just as good as it was when it was announced several thousand years ago.

And I think that the objective of the Atlantic Charter is just as sound, if you believe in that kind of objective — some people don't, some people laugh at it — just as valid as when it was announced in 1941.

There are a lot of people who say you can't attain an objective or improvement in human life or in humanity, therefore why talk about it. Well, those people who come out for the Ten Commandments will say we don't all live up to the Ten Commandments, which is perfectly true, but on the

whole they are pretty good. It's something pretty good to shoot for. The Christian religion most of us in the room happen to belong to, we think it is pretty good. We certainly haven't attained it. Well, the Atlantic Charter is going to take its place, not comparing it with the Christian religion or the Ten Commandments, but as a definite step, just the same way as Wilson's Fourteen Points constituted a major contribution to something we would all like to see happen in the world. Well, those Fourteen Points weren't all attained, but it was a step towards a better life for the population of the world.

And every once in a while somebody comes forward with something else, and will in the future. It depends a little bit on how you are built.

Q. Mr. President, did you mean to imply by that that we are as far from attaining the ends of the Atlantic Charter as the world was a thousand years ago?

THE PRESIDENT: Oh, no. Oh, no. The world goes a little bit by peaks and valleys, but on the whole the curve is upward; on the whole, over these thousands of years human life is on a great deal better scale than it was then. And we have got a long way to go.

But things are better, and things are going to get better, if we work for it. There are some people who don't like to work for it — some people in this room — who are — what will I say? — congenitally "agin" that sort of thing. Well, that is part of the peaks and valleys. . . .

Q. Mr. President, have there been any further developments toward a meeting between the Big Three?

THE PRESIDENT: Not yet. And, by the way, when it is — when a development is made, you won't be told. *(Laughter)* There is such a thing known as security for a ship or for a plane, which we have to maintain, as we have in the past. It would be vital about maintaining it when they have known about the fact that I had gone — a pretty good guess as to which way I had gone would be the same thing.

MR. EARLY: Make that off the record.

THE PRESIDENT: Yes. That's off the record.

Q. Is there any chance of inviting or bringing, then, Mr. Stalin here, do you think?

THE PRESIDENT: No.

Q. Mr. President—

THE PRESIDENT: *(interposing)* That has to be off the record.

Q. That's all off the record, too?

THE PRESIDENT: Yes.

Q. Mr. President, is there anything that could be said to further our understanding as to what has held up this meeting up to this point? Since you have said you were anxious to meet, Mr. Churchill has said the same thing.

THE PRESIDENT: Well, again, I have got to tell you off the record. It's largely a question of geography. There aren't three people in the same place. You can't hold a conference in several different places. There has got to be one place. That has to be off the record, too. In other words, to find a place that three of us can go to.

Q. Does the fact that the Premier of Russia is also actively at the head of the armed forces have a bearing on that?

THE PRESIDENT: Oh, yes. Oh, yes. Oh, all kinds of factors. . . .

Q. Mr. President, there has been some discussion of a joint chiefs of staff for political and economic questions, similar to the joint chiefs of staff for military questions. Is there anything comparable to that in contemplation?

THE PRESIDENT: I think that was a columnist suggested that, wasn't it? It was a columnist, that's right. All we can say is that columnists are with us, an unnecessary excrescence on our civilization. Excuse me. *(Laughter)*

MAY CRAIG: *(interposing)* But you have one in the family! [Mrs. Roosevelt's column, "My Day."] *(Loud laughter)*

THE PRESIDENT: *(laughing)* Yes, that's true. That's different. *(continued laughter)* Very good — very good. That's perfectly true, May, but it's a little bit different. Mostly it's a diary. *(More laughter)* . . .

NOTE: For the official statement on the Atlantic Charter, and subsequent comments by the President on the Atlantic Charter, see Items 74, 76, 77, and 78, 1941 volume; Item 82, 1942 volume; Item 90, 1943 volume; and Item 120, this volume.

122 ¶ Christmas Eve Address to the Nation. December 24, 1944

IT IS NOT easy to say "Merry Christmas" to you, my fellow Americans, in this time of destructive war. Nor can I say "Merry Christmas" lightly tonight to our armed forces at their battle stations all over the world — or to our allies who fight by their side.

Here, at home, we will celebrate this Christmas Day in our traditional American way — because of its deep spiritual meaning to us; because the teachings of Christ are fundamental in our lives; and because we want our youngest generation to grow up knowing the significance of this tradition and the story of the coming of the immortal Prince of Peace and Good Will. But, in perhaps every home in the United States, sad and anxious thoughts will be continually with the millions of our loved ones who are suffering hardships and misery, and who are risking their very lives to preserve for us and for all mankind the fruits of His teachings and the foundations of civilization itself.

The Christmas spirit lives tonight in the bitter cold of the front lines in Europe and in the heat of the jungles and swamps of Burma and the Pacific islands. Even the roar of our bombers and fighters in the air and the guns of our ships at sea will not drown out the messages of Christmas which come to the hearts of our fighting men. The thoughts of these men tonight will turn to us here at home around our Christmas trees, surrounded by our children and grandchildren and their Christmas stockings and gifts — just as our own thoughts go out to them, tonight and every night, in their distant places.

We all know how anxious they are to be home with us, and